# GET USERS

Understand your funnel. Drive traffic.

# USER COUNT LEADERBOARD

Starting today, we track this every class. Zero is fine. Zero is visible.

| | | | | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Sift | - | Vouch | | QuestCity | — | Rekindled | 0 |
| Roam | 0 | Circle | 0 | FreeWeight | 0 | Recruitr | 3 |
| Misfit AI | 0 | Evidence of Life | — | NoticeMe | 0 | Standard Deviants | 0 |

# PIRATE METRICS

# WHY AARRR?

Without a framework, founders diagnose by guessing:

- ✗ *"We need more marketing."* — Maybe. Or maybe 90% of people who find you leave without getting the point.
- ✗ *"The product isn't sticky."* — Maybe. Or maybe users who reach the aha moment DO come back — but almost no one is reaching it yet.
- ✗ *"Nobody wants this."* — Maybe. Or maybe the landing page is just terrible and the product is fine.

💡 **AARRR is a diagnostic map.** It doesn't tell you IF something is broken — it tells you *WHERE* in the customer journey it broke. Different problems. Different fixes.

# AARRR — THE FIVE STAGES

| STAGE | THE QUESTION | WHAT YOU DO | WHAT YOU MEASURE |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Acquisition** | Are people finding you? | Drive traffic — any channel | Visitors, signups, traffic source |
| **Activation** | Are they reaching the aha moment? | Fix onboarding — **today's focus** | % completing key first action |
| **Retention** | Are they coming back? | Deliver ongoing value | DAU/WAU, return rate, churn |
| **Referral** | Are they telling others? | Build in sharing / delight | Referral rate, NPS, viral coefficient |
| **Revenue** | Are they paying? | Monetize the value delivered | MRR, LTV, conversion rate |

Each stage is a gate. You can't skip one and hope for the best — you can't retain users who never activated, and you can't get referrals from users who didn't stay.

# OTHER FRAMEWORKS

AARRR isn't the only framework. Here's how it compares:

### North Star Metric

One number that captures your core value. Airbnb: nights booked. Spotify: time spent listening. Forces focus — but doesn't tell you *where* you're leaking.

### HEART (Google)

Happiness, Engagement, Adoption, Retention, Task Success. More user-experience-focused than growth-focused. Better for mature products optimizing quality, not early-stage finding product-market fit.

### Jobs-to-be-Done

Focuses on *why* users hire your product, not what they do in it. Great for discovery and positioning. Doesn't give you the funnel metrics to diagnose where users drop off.

💡 These aren't competing — they answer different questions. AARRR answers "where in the funnel are we losing people?" Use it alongside a North Star, not instead of one.

# WHERE ARE YOU RIGHT NOW?

| Acquisition | Activation | Retention | Referral | Revenue |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| Are people finding you? | Are they reaching the aha moment? | Are they coming back? | Are they telling others? | Are they paying? |
| 😬 | ❓ | ⏳ | ⏳ | ⏳ |
| **Most: barely** | **Most: unknown** | Later | Later | Later |

⚡ Most teams are at 0–10 users. **You don't actually know if your activation works.** That changes today.

# ACTIVATION IS THE GATE

**Scenario A: Traffic-first**

1,000 visitors/month
× 5% activation rate

= **50 active users**

**Scenario B: Fix activation first**

100 visitors/month
× 50% activation rate

= **50 active users**

Same result. 10× less traffic. The lever is activation, not acquisition.

Every user who doesn't activate is a user who leaves without learning whether they wanted your product. You can't retain someone who never got the point.

💡 Fix onboarding before scaling traffic. Otherwise you're filling a leaky bucket.

# YOUR AHA MOMENT

**When does a user first understand why your product exists?**

**Slack:**
"I can message my whole team in one place and search it later"

**Airbnb:**
"Real people's apartments — cheaper and more interesting than a hotel"

**Dropbox:**
"My file is just... there, on my other computer"

**2 minutes — your team:**

Complete this sentence:

*"The first time a user gets it is when they _____ and realize _____."*

If you can't finish this sentence, your onboarding probably doesn't get them there either.

# SO HOW DO WE KNOW IF IT'S WORKING?

You now know **what** activation is. The question is: **how do you find out if yours works?**

### User Testing

Watch real people try to use your product.

You see exactly where they get confused, what they expect, and whether they reach the aha moment — or give up trying.

Answers: **WHY** they get stuck

### Analytics

Measure what happens at scale with GA4 and Amplitude.

You see how many people drop off at each step across all your users — not just the three you watched.

Answers: **HOW MANY** get stuck

These two methods feed into each other. We'll cover both today.

# USER TESTING

# DIDN'T WE TALK TO PEOPLE LAST WEEK?

Last week, you had other teams walk through your product and give feedback.

### What you did last week

Peers with product experience walked through your onboarding and flagged issues — terminology, flows, missing context.

**Expert Review**

### What you're doing today

Real target users — with no product experience and no context — try to accomplish tasks on their own. You observe silently.

**Usability Testing**

💡 Both are legitimate UX research methods. Expert review is faster and finds obvious issues. Usability testing finds things experts miss — because experts already know how your product works.

# YOU DON'T NEED 50 TESTERS

**3–5**

users reveals

**~85%**

of usability problems

More users after 5 gives **diminishing returns**. The most obvious problems will get hit over and over.

For UX, better to do small number of tests and rapidly iterate, rather than aiming for comprehensive coverage or stat sig.

💡 **Don't wait for a perfect recruitment plan.** Find 3 people this week. Start now.

Source: Nielsen Norman Group — Why You Only Need to Test with 5 Users

# STRANGERS > FRIENDS

**Friends will be nice.**

- Fill in your gaps with imagination
- Already know your product from you talking about it
- Won't tell you when something is confusing
- Their social desirability bias is your blind spot

**Strangers will struggle.**

- Arrive completely cold — like real users
- Won't apologize for confusion
- Click the wrong things without explaining
- Their confusion IS the data

You can start with friends — better than nothing. But push toward strangers.

📖 This is the **Mom Test** principle (Week 4). Don't ask people who want you to succeed.

# HOW TO FIND PEOPLE

### Reddit

r/[relevant community]
r/beermoney
"20-min test, $10 Venmo"

### Craigslist gigs

Same offer.
Title: "Paid usability test, 20 min"

### Discord / Slack

Communities where your actual target users hang out

### Cold DMs

LinkedIn, Instagram, Twitter — wherever your target users are

### Columbia network

Students and staff you don't know personally

### Friends / classmates

OK to start. Lower quality data. Fine for session 1.

💡 **Offer $10/session** (Venmo / PayPal / gift card). Compensation dramatically increases response rates from strangers.

# CONSENT FORM

When recruiting strangers, use one.

**What it covers:**

- What the session is (user testing to improve a product)
- How notes will be used (to improve the product, shared with the class)
- No personal data stored or shared
- Right to stop at any time
- Recording consent (if applicable)

📄 **Template in Github.** Copy it, fill in your product name and contact info.

💡 **People you know well:** verbal consent is fine. Strangers: written consent.

# HOW TO RUN THE SESSION

1

### BRIEF THEM

"I'm going to have you try to use our product. Please think out loud — say what you're looking at and what you're thinking. I won't help you. There are no wrong answers."

2

### WATCH AND LISTEN.

Hand over the laptop or URL. Prompt them with the tasks you would like them to follow, or let them explore.

3

### DON'T HELP.

If they click the wrong thing: let them struggle. If they get completely stuck: "What are you looking for?" — then stop. Do not answer the question.

4

### POST-SESSION QUESTIONS

"What was the first moment you understood what this is for?" · "What was most confusing?" · "Would you use this again?" · "If you could wave a magic wand and change one thing, what would it be?"

# NOTE BEHAVIOR, NOT OPINION

**Not this (opinion)**

*"She said she found it confusing."*
*"He thought it was interesting."*
*"They liked the concept."*

**This (behavior)**

*"She clicked the X three times before finding the nav button."*
*"He paused for 8 seconds on the sign-up form."*
*"They went back to the home page without completing step 2."*

## What to look for:

**Hesitations** — pause before clicking

**Wrong clicks** — wrong path first

**Questions out loud** — "Wait, so this is...?"

**Dropped tasks** — gave up

**Workarounds** — unexpected path

🎥 **Screen recordings are gold.** When you go back to write your synthesis, you'll catch things you missed live — how long they hovered, where the mouse went, micro-hesitations. Use Loom or QuickTime to record the participant's screen with their consent.

# INTERVIEW SCRIPT TEMPLATE

Start from this. Customize the tasks for your product.

### INTRO

*"I'm going to have you try to use our product. Please think out loud — say whatever's on your mind. I won't help you. There are no wrong answers. We're testing the product, not you."*

### TASKS

**1.** "Go to [URL]. What do you think this product does?"

**2.** "Please try to sign up."

**3.** [Product-specific task → leads to aha moment]

*"Try to find something to do this weekend" / "Create your first [thing]"*

### POST-SESSION

"When did you first understand what this is for?"

"What was the most confusing part?"

"What would have made it easier?"

"Would you use this again? Why or why not?"

Template shared as Google Doc in Discord — copy and customize. Task 3 is yours to write — it should lead directly to your aha moment.

# NOW THE QUANTITATIVE HALF

You've learned user testing: how to watch people try to activate. Now the other half.

**User Testing ✓**
WHY — you can see it

→

**Analytics**
HOW MANY — measure it at scale

Find the problem in sessions. Confirm it's systematic in the data. Fix it. Run both again.

# ANALYTICS

# GA4 + AMPLITUDE: WHY BOTH

📊

### Google Analytics 4

*Outside the product — how they got to you*

- Pageviews, sessions, traffic sources
- Where users come from (organic, direct, ads)
- Google Ads integration for ad tracking
- Industry standard. Free.
- Course certification requirement

📈

### Amplitude

*Inside the product — what they actually do*

- Custom events you instrument yourself
- Funnel analysis — where users drop off
- User paths, cohorts, retention
- Free tier is generous

GA4 tells you how people arrived. Amplitude tells you what they did once they were there.

📱 **Building a mobile app?** Amplitude has native iOS and Android SDKs — same events, same funnels. Firebase Analytics is the mobile equivalent of GA4 and plugs into the same Google ecosystem.

# WHAT TO INSTRUMENT

Track every step in each flow. Drop-off can happen anywhere.

### Acquisition flow

Landing page viewed

↓

CTA clicked

↓

Sign-up page viewed

*Where do people bounce before they even try?*

### Sign-up flow

Email entered

↓

Password set

↓

Email verified

↓

**Account created ✓**

*"Sign-up completed" alone hides where they drop.*

### Activation flow

[First in-app action]

↓

[Step 2 — your product]

↓

**Aha moment reached ✓**

*Every step in your aha journey should be tracked.*

⚠ If you only track "sign-up completed," you'll never know if people drop off at email verification vs. password setup. **Granularity is the point.** Each step is a separate event.

# THIS WEEK: GET SET UP

**Install GA4**
Add the tracking snippet to your app. Set up conversion events for steps 1-3. skillshop.google.com

**Install Amplitude**
Add the SDK. Track steps 3-5 as Amplitude events. amplitude.com — free tier is enough.

**Google Analytics Certification**
Complete this alongside your GA4 installation — you're learning the tool you're configuring.

**You can't analyze data you haven't collected. Start this week.**

# THE CLOCK IS RUNNING

| 3 | 6 | 0 |
|---|---|---|
| **weeks** | **weeks** | **weeks** |
| of building time left before feature freeze | to Demo Day | to start getting users |
| Apr 23 | May 12 | tonight |

Everything from here is in service of one loop:

**Get users** → **Learn from them** → **Ship what matters** → **repeat**

No more exploring. You have a product. Now find out if people can use it and build the parts that make them stay.

# YOUR ASSIGNMENT

# TRACK A: QUALITATIVE

### 3–5 User Testing Sessions

DUE TUESDAY, APRIL 7

- Run sessions on your onboarding flow — strangers give better signal than people who know you
- Use the consent form for anyone recruited via Reddit, Craigslist, or cold DM
- Use the interview script template as your starting point

**Deliverable:** A short synthesis + product recommendation:

**What we observed:** [pattern that appeared across sessions]
**What we're changing:** [specific product change]
**Why:** [what the sessions showed that led to this decision]

# TRACK B: QUANTITATIVE + GROWTH

DUE THURSDAY, APRIL 2

**Analytics installed + funnel tracking live**
GA4 + Amplitude both running, all funnel events firing

THU APR 2

**Expose a user count API endpoint**
`GET /api/user-count` → JSON. Powers the automatic leaderboard.

THU APR 2

**Growth Strategy Doc — Part 1**
Which channels are you targeting? What's your approach? What does success look like?

THU APR 2

DUE THURSDAY, APRIL 9

**Drive 20+ users to your product**
Any channel. The goal is real funnel data — not just installs.

THU APR 9

# THE GROWTH STRATEGY DOC

Start with a plan. Then fill in what happened.

## Part 1 — Your Plan (fill out today)

**Channels you're targeting**
Which 2–3 channels will you focus on this week? Be specific — not just "social media" but "Instagram DMs to food bloggers in NYC."

**Approach for each**
What will you say? What's the offer? What's your target volume per channel?

**What success looks like**
How will you know if a channel is working?

## Part 2 — What Happened (fill out by Apr 9)

**Results per channel**
Views, clicks, sign-ups, activations. Use your funnel data.

**What worked / what didn't**
A conclusion from data, not a guess.

**What you're changing next**
"We're doubling down on X because Y."

🤖 **Part 1 — use AI to plan.** *"I'm building [product] for [audience]. What acquisition channels should I try first and how should I approach each?"*

🤖 **Part 2 — use AI to analyze.** *"Here are my results by channel. What worked, what didn't, and what should I focus on next?"*

# THURSDAY: AI FOR YOUR PRODUCT

Part 2 of the two-class AI arc.

- System prompts — the invisible hand shaping every AI product
- Prompt engineering for products — designing with LLMs, not just using them
- Agentic design patterns — basic completion → tool-augmented → multi-agent
- RAG + MCP — making AI work with your own data
- Design exercise — using your actual AI features as the context

# GET USERS.
# START TONIGHT.

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